

Giap's strategy

The Viet Minh organized guerrilla forces at three levels. Village militia comprised part-time soldiers—peasants who used improvised weapons in clandestine attacks on enemy soldiers or officials in their locality. Regional forces operated in their own districts and provinces. The main-force guerrillas trained with the best available arms at remote bases in mountain and jungle areas, ready to be deployed for major operations.

The point of a guerrilla strategy was to allow a weaker military force to triumph over a stronger enemy by avoiding a direct trial of strength until conditions were advantageous. Despite some costly mistakes, Giap mostly chose his occasions for battle wisely, attacking exposed outposts or ambushing forces on the move. The great strength of the Viet Minh lay in its understanding of the importance of morale and political commitment in war. They aimed to demoralize the French and win the support of the Vietnamese people. This was relatively easy, as the vast majority of the population hated French rule. Viet Minh propaganda always stressed nationalism, with no mention of communism, of which most Vietnamese had no knowledge.

By the early 1950s, the Viet Minh had control of large areas of Vietnam, where they collected taxes and rice. Even in areas supposedly under French control, the Viet Minh often operated freely at night, carrying out terror attacks against officials and soldiers.



Planning an operation

General Vo Nguyen Giap briefs his officers on the details of a planned engagement at Dien Bien Phu in 1954. Despite an apparently relaxed style of command suitable to guerrilla forces, Giap demanded absolute discipline and obedience to orders.

Inspiration

The success of the Viet Minh campaign, culminating in the humiliation of French troops at Dien Bien Phu in 1954, encouraged other would-be revolutionaries to take up arms. Just as they were admitting defeat in Vietnam, the French faced a fresh guerrilla campaign